The third and most widespread technique for maintaining state is to use cookies. A cookie is a bit of information that the server can give to a client. On every subsequent request the client will give that information back to the server, thus identifying itself. Cookies are useful for retaining information through repeated visits by a browser, but they're not without their own problems. The main problem is that most browsers allow users to disable cookies. So any application that uses cookies for state maintenance needs to use another technique as a fallback mechanism.

The best way to maintain state with PHP is to use the built-in session-tracking system. This system lets you create persistent variables that are accessible from different pages of your application, as well as in different visits to the site by the same user. Behind the scenes, PHP's session-tracking mechanism uses cookies (or URLs) to elegantly solve most problems that require state, taking care of all the details for you.

Remember

URL is a reference to a web resource that specifies its location on a computer network and a mechanism for retrieving it.

7.2.1 Cookies

Cookies are text files stored on the client computer and they are kept of use tracking purpose. PHP transparently supports HTTP cookies.

There are three steps involved in identifying returning users –

- Server script sends a set of cookies to the browser. For example, name, age, or identification number etc.
- Browser stores this information on local machine for future use.
- When next time browser sends any request to web server then it sends those cookies information to the server and server uses that information to identify the user.

The Anatomy of a Cookie

Cookies are usually set in an **HTTP** header (although JavaScript can also set a cookie directly on a browser). A PHP script that sets a cookie might send headers that look something like this –